

Idea Exploration Workbook

SB Pathways — Guided Business Exploration

This workbook is designed to help you thoughtfully explore a business idea before making major commitments of time, money, or energy.

The goal is not perfection. The goal is clarity.

Use this workbook to organize your thinking, identify opportunities and risks, and better understand the potential path ahead.

SB Pathways

Guided support for practical small business decision-making.

Section 1 — The Big Idea

Describe your idea at a high level.

- What is your business idea?

- What inspired the idea?

- Why does this opportunity interest you?

- Why now?

Pause & Reflect:

What feels strongest about this idea right now? What still feels uncertain?

Section 2 — The Problem

Strong businesses solve meaningful problems.

- What problem does this business solve?

- Who experiences this problem?

- How are people solving this today?

- Why might your solution be different or better?

Pause & Reflect:

What feels strongest about this idea right now? What still feels uncertain?

Section 3 — The Customer

Understanding the customer is critical.

- Who is most likely to buy this?

- What are they struggling with?

- What matters most to them?

- Why would they choose your business?

Pause & Reflect:

What feels strongest about this idea right now? What still feels uncertain?

Section 4 — Market Reality Check

Evaluate the market honestly and objectively.

- Who are the competitors?

- Is demand already proven?

- What concerns or risks do you see?

- Is this idea seasonal or trend-based?

Pause & Reflect:

What feels strongest about this idea right now? What still feels uncertain?

Section 5 — Financial Snapshot

Basic financial awareness matters early.

- Estimated startup costs?

- Expected monthly expenses?

- Potential pricing?

- How many sales might be needed monthly?

Pause & Reflect:

What feels strongest about this idea right now? What still feels uncertain?

Section 6 — Founder Readiness

Assess your own readiness realistically.

- How much time can you commit?

- What skills do you already have?

- What support or resources are missing?

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- What concerns or fears do you have?

Pause & Reflect:

What feels strongest about this idea right now? What still feels uncertain?

Section 7 — Small-Scale Testing

Explore ways to test the idea with low risk.

- How could you test this idea inexpensively?

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- Who could you talk to for feedback?

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- Could you pilot or pre-sell the idea?

- What would help validate demand?

Pause & Reflect:

What feels strongest about this idea right now? What still feels uncertain?

Final Reflection & Next Steps

This workbook is not intended to “approve” or “reject” your idea.

Instead, it is designed to help you think more clearly, reduce risk, and identify practical next steps.

Strong businesses are often built through:

- testing
- learning
- adapting
- and refining over time

You do not need to have every answer immediately. Clarity develops through thoughtful exploration and action.

Suggested Next Steps:

- Continue market research
- Talk to potential customers
- Explore startup costs
- Seek advisor feedback
- Test the idea on a small scale